

The United Arab Emirates (UAE): Issues for U.S. Policy

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The United Arab Emirates (UAE) is a federation of seven principalities or “emirates.” Its population is 10 million, of which nearly 90% are expatriates from within and outside the region who work in its economy. The UAE is a U.S.-designated “major defense partner” that hosts U.S. military personnel at UAE military facilities and buys sophisticated U.S. military equipment, including missile defenses and combat aircraft. From 1950 to 2023, the United States implemented more than \$33.5 billion in Foreign Military Sales for the UAE, making it the 14th largest U.S. defense customer by foreign military sales value worldwide.

The conflict in the Gulf that began in February 2026 has dramatically affected the UAE’s security and economy. Since the conflict started, Iran has targeted the UAE more than any other Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) state. During the initial months of the conflict, Iranian projectiles or debris from intercepted projectiles struck several critical sites inside the UAE. In response to restrictions on traffic transiting the Strait of Hormuz, the UAE has accelerated efforts to construct infrastructure designed to bypass the Strait, including ports and pipelines. Overall, while the UAE remains in a far better economic position than some of its GCC neighbors, the conflict in the Gulf has disrupted foreign investment and tourism.

While the UAE has been vulnerable to Iranian attacks, it has aligned itself with the United States’ Operation Economic Outcast to pressure Iran financially. To date, Emirati authorities have halted commercial air traffic to/from Iran and sanctioned Iranian banks operating in Dubai. Although the current situation remains fluid, regardless of the Iran conflict’s outcome, the UAE appears unlikely to retreat from its ambitions to become a global commercial center, even if the current war has increased the cost of pursuing those ambitions.

Beyond Iran, the UAE has continued to maintain close ties to Israel. Emirati-Israeli relations, which have been defined by the post-October 7, 2023, conflicts in Gaza, Lebanon, and Iran, have witnessed unprecedented levels of military cooperation following normalization in 2020, but also strained diplomatic ties over Israeli military action across the Middle East. As civil war in Sudan continues between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF), press reports and UN sanctions monitors have implicated the UAE in backing the RSF. Several Members of Congress have formally expressed concerns over the UAE’s reported role in the Sudan conflict. In the 119th Congress, Representative Sara Jacobs and Senator Chris Van Hollen reintroduced legislation (H.R. 2059 and S. 935) to restrict arms exports licenses to the UAE until the Trump Administration can certify that the UAE is not supplying arms to the RSF. Other Members, such as Senator Joni Ernst, have spoken in favor of the continued U.S.-UAE defense partnership.

Over the past two decades, the UAE has become one of the United States’ closest partners in the Middle East region. Those ties have been strengthened during the Trump Administration. Gulf countries like the UAE have increasingly emerged as arenas for competition with the People’s Republic of China, particularly in the race for artificial intelligence (AI) dominance. In January 2026, the UAE joined Pax Silica, the U.S. State Department’s multilateral AI and supply chain security initiative. In July 2026, the Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) at the U.S. Department of Commerce issued the rule, “Enhanced Favorable Treatment for the United Arab Emirates under the Export Administration Regulations (“Rule”),” which upgrades the export control status of the UAE, thereby facilitating the export of certain sensitive U.S. technologies. Under the new rule, UAE AI companies may no longer need individual export licenses for the purchase of U.S. AI chips and servers.

In 2025, the UAE was the largest U.S. trading partner by value (\$39 billion) in the Middle East and North Africa region. The UAE has remained the top U.S. export destination for the entire MENA region for the 17th year in a row, and the United States has a trade surplus of \$23 billion with the UAE.

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Overview

The United Arab Emirates (UAE) is a federation of seven principalities, or “emirates” (see **Figure 1**). Its population is 10 million, of whom nearly 90% are expatriates from within and outside the Middle East region. The UAE accounts for 4% of the world’s annual oil production and was the world’s 8th largest oil producer in 2025.¹ Having benefitted from decades of oil revenue and having pursued a host of economic diversification and global investment initiatives, the UAE is a high-income nation; the International Monetary Fund ranks it 14th globally in Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per capita.² The UAE’s national wealth gives the small country outsized global influence; its various sovereign wealth funds alone manage assets totaling over \$3.1 trillion, allowing the UAE to make investments globally, including in the United States.³

The UAE and the Conflict in the Gulf

The conflict in the Gulf that began in February has dramatically affected the UAE’s security and economy, accelerating the Emirates’ longstanding pursuit of policies independent of other members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), even as it remains dependent on U.S. defense ties. The UAE may be the most financially resilient GCC member state, though its economy’s dependence on international commerce, global air and maritime transit, and foreign labor creates vulnerabilities to sustained disruption from the Iran conflict. In light of both the UAE’s setbacks and resilience, it is an open question as to how viable the “UAE model” (i.e., an innovative Gulf state attempting to forge a non-oil economy while still remaining tethered to the United States’ security umbrella) is in the face of Iranian threats. The conflict has complicated the UAE’s traditional attempts at retaining residual diplomatic and commercial links to Iran (**see below**).

¹ The Energy Institute, “Statistical Review of World Energy (73rd Edition),” 2024; U.S. Department of Energy, Energy Information Administration, “The United States produced more crude oil than any other country in 2025,” July 9, 2026.

² See, International Monetary Fund, “IMF Data Mapper: United Arab Emirates Datasets; World Economic Outlook (December 2025); GDP per capita, current prices, purchasing power parity; international dollars per capita.”

³ Global SWF (Sovereign Wealth Funds) Data Platform, Rankings, accessed September 2026.

Figure I. UAE at a Glance



Population	10 million, of whom about 11% are Emirati citizens.
Religions	Of total population, 75% Muslim; 13% Christian; and 12% other (primarily Buddhist or Hindu).
Population Components	Emirati (citizenry) 11%; South Asian; 59% (Indian, Pakistani, Bangladeshi); Egyptian 10%; Filipino 6%; other 13%.

Sources: Map created by CRS. Facts from CIA, *The World Factbook*; Economist Intelligence Unit; and Global SWF.

Since the conflict began in February 2026, Iran has targeted the UAE more than any other GCC state.⁴ The UAE has reportedly retaliated with airstrikes of its own against Iranian energy sites.⁵ While missile defense systems, including Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) installations and at least one Iron Dome battery operated by Israeli soldiers, have intercepted the vast majority of Iranian projectiles targeting the UAE, damage from those that penetrated Emirati defenses has been substantial enough to accelerate longstanding defense and economic plans aimed at greater self-sufficiency.⁶

Damage to Critical Infrastructure, U.S. Assets, and AI

During the initial months of the conflict, Iranian projectiles or debris from intercepted projectiles struck several critical sites, including an electrical generator in the Barakah Nuclear Power Plant.

⁴ "Live Dashboard: The Campaign Against Iran and the Shiite Axis," The Institute for National Security Studies (INSS), last updated September 2, 2026.

⁵ Summer Said and Anat Peled, "The U.A.E.'s Secret Role in the War Involved Dozens of Strikes on Iran," *Wall Street Journal*, May 29, 2026.

⁶ Farah Stockman and Ismaeel Naar, "The U.S. Start-Up Making Low-Cost Interceptors for the Iran War," *New York Times*, August 23, 2026.

The Habshan gas processing plant, which was twice damaged by debris from intercepted drones, is not expected to be fully operational again until 2027, assuming it sustains no further damage.⁷ Iranian attacks also have damaged UAE aluminum smelters. Emirates Global Aluminum's main smelter is undergoing an estimated \$400 million in repairs and is expected to return to full operation in 2027.⁸ Almost 90% of high-purity aluminum used in the United States to make certain types of defense equipment, including fighter aircraft, comes from the UAE.⁹

Iran also struck Al Dhafra Air Base, which is used by both U.S. and French military forces. Several hangars sustained fire and roof damage according to commercial satellite imagery.¹⁰ Iran also damaged the U.S. Consulate General in Dubai.¹¹

In order to adjust to Iranian attacks using one-way attack drones, the UAE has adopted tactics from the war in Ukraine and built "cope cages," or metal caging constructed around critical infrastructure such as fuel tanks.¹² In March 2026, the UAE signed a ten-year military-technical cooperation agreement with Ukraine, and several Ukrainian military experts have been stationed in the UAE to advise defense officials on counter-drone techniques.¹³ The UAE's main defense conglomerate, Edge Group, is partnering with South Korea to create an integrated air defense system against higher-tier threats, such as ballistic missiles.¹⁴

As the UAE has attempted to position itself as a regional leader in artificial intelligence (AI), and the Trump Administration has facilitated the approval of export licenses for sensitive AI technologies to the UAE,¹⁵ Iran also has proven it can damage the UAE's nascent AI industry, exposing its vulnerabilities. Earlier in 2026, Iran damaged an Amazon Web Services facility in Abu Dhabi, forcing the company to temporarily move its data centers elsewhere until repairs can be completed; that same facility (Stargate UAE) also was to house OpenAI servers, but OpenAI has yet to sign a lease there, perhaps due to the continuation of conflict.¹⁶ Reports now indicate that the UAE may be planning on dispersing AI infrastructure and moving some data facilities underground.¹⁷ Others suggest that while the Iran conflict may have temporarily set back U.S.-UAE AI partnerships, competition with China and the demand for data centers and capital means

⁷ "UAE Gas Plant Hit by Iranian Attacks Will Not Be Fully Repaired Until 2027," *Financial Times*, May 12, 2026.

⁸ "UAE Aims to Restore War-Hit Aluminum Output in First Quarter," *Bloomberg*, August 12, 2026.

⁹ Kelsey Warner, "War validates UAE metals move to US," *Semafor*, August 6, 2026.

¹⁰ John Gambrell, "Satellite images begin to show damage wrought by Iran war," Associated Press, March 31, 2026.

¹¹ Lead Inspector General Report to the United States Congress, Operation Epic Fury, September 14, 2026.

¹² Howard Altman, "UAE Building Massive 'Cope Cages' To Protect Energy Facilities From Iranian Drone Attacks," *The War Zone*, May 13, 2026.

¹³ Eugene Chausovsky, "The Gulf Looks to Ukraine as Global Conflicts Converge," *Gulf International Forum*, August 6, 2026.

¹⁴ Jeremy Binnie, "Hanwha, Edge partnering on UAE's integrated air defence," *Jane's Defence Weekly*, September 22, 2026.

¹⁵ On July 10, 2026, the Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) at the U.S. Department of Commerce issued the rule, "Enhanced Favorable Treatment for the United Arab Emirates under the Export Administration Regulations ("Rule")," which upgrades the export control status of the UAE, thereby facilitating the export of certain sensitive U.S. technologies. See, "Enhanced Favorable Treatment for the United Arab Emirates Under the Export Administration Regulations," A Rule by the Industry and Security Bureau, July 14, 2026. According to one account, under the new rule, UAE AI companies may no longer need individual export licenses for AI chips and servers. See, "US makes it easier to export Nvidia AI chips and military equipment to the UAE," Reuters, July 10, 2026.

¹⁶ Omar Abdel-Baqui and Eliot Brown, "Iran's Drones Deal Blow to Ambition Of Gulf Data Sites," *Wall Street Journal*, September 15, 2026.

¹⁷ "UAE revises AI data center plan after Iranian attacks, sources say," Reuters, September 11, 2026.

that “Both sides are too dependent on each other, and neither side can step back.”¹⁸ Microsoft is continuing to invest in the UAE, where it has a minority stake in the AI company, G42.¹⁹

The Economy and the UAE’s “Zero Hormuz Strategy”

Beyond the physical damage suffered by the UAE, Iran’s attempts to assert control of the Strait of Hormuz have challenged the UAE’s existing approach to energy exports and positioning as a global hub for commerce. In response, the UAE, which exited the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) in May 2026, has accelerated efforts to construct infrastructure designed to bypass the Strait, including ports and pipelines. DP World plans to build two new deep-water terminals within two years on the UAE’s eastern coast, outside the Strait, in the emirate of Fujairah.²⁰ The UAE has increased overland trucking, maximized crude oil exports through existing pipelines, purchased additional oil tankers, and reportedly directed shippers to “go dark” by turning off their transponders in hopes of evading Iranian attacks.²¹ The Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) reportedly moved more oil through the Strait of Hormuz than any other producer during June and July 2026.²² Recent reports indicate that Iran’s attempts to limit tanker traffic transiting the Strait may be diminishing, as overall crude exports from Gulf producers rebounded in September 2026 to their highest levels since the conflict started in February.²³

As of September 30, the International Maritime Organization has tracked at least 17 Iranian attacks against tankers near or within the UAE’s territorial waters.²⁴ Although Gulf exporters have sought to reduce Iran’s ability to disrupt their economies, these workarounds, according to one UAE-based academic, have “not been enough to render Iran’s veto irrelevant” given the proven capability of Iran and its allies to strike targets throughout the Gulf region.²⁵ The additional port capacity now under construction is reportedly insufficient to compensate for the tonnage stranded at major existing facilities, such as Jebel Ali in Dubai and Khalifa Port in Abu Dhabi.²⁶

As UAE officials have characterized the current situation in the Gulf as “neither war nor peace,”²⁷ 2026 gross domestic product projections for the UAE vary widely depending on the source. The UAE Central Bank anticipates 2026 GDP growth of 1.7% this year, while other projections estimate a slight contraction for the UAE economy.²⁸ Overall, while the UAE remains in a far better economic position than some of its GCC neighbors, the conflict in the Gulf has disrupted foreign investment and tourism. In response, the UAE government has offered business subsidies,

¹⁸ Rachel Chason and Evan Halper, “UAE views Trump as key partner in push to become AI powerhouse,” *Washington Post*, August 28, 2026.

¹⁹ Federico Maccioni, “Microsoft plans \$10bn-plus Gulf investment and a focus on resilience,” *Irish Independent*, September 24, 2026.

²⁰ “Fujairah rises as key gateway outside Strait of Hormuz,” *Economist Intelligence Unit*, July 30, 2026.

²¹ The Habshan-Fujairah pipeline is currently carrying 1.8 million barrels per day (bpd), up from 1 million bpd before the war. See, “How long can Iran weaponise Hormuz?” *The Economist*, August 4, 2026.

²² “UAE Defies Hormuz Risks to Keep Crude Flowing to Global Market,” *Bloomberg*, August 5, 2026.

²³ “Oil prices settle down 2.5% on signs Middle East exports recovering,” Reuters, September 29, 2026.

²⁴ International Maritime Organization, “Middle East - Highlighted (Confirmed) incidents,” as of September 30, 2026.

²⁵ Summer Said and Benoit Faucon, “Gulf States Are Resigned to Iran Control of Strait,” *Wall Street Journal*, August 11, 2026.

²⁶ “Gulf ports not easily replaced,” *Semafor*, August 3, 2026.

²⁷ “Region’s ‘neither war nor peace’ state: UAE’s Gargash calls for ‘realistic solutions,’” *Khaleej Times*, August 31, 2026.

²⁸ “‘Neither War, Nor Peace:’ UAE Returns to a New Normal,” *Bloomberg*, September 13, 2026; Economist Intelligence Unit, Viewpoint UAE, August 31, 2026.

waived fees and taxes, and provided other forms of incentives to attract foreign capital, visitors, and entertainers.²⁹

UAE Policy Toward Iran and Sanctions

Like U.S. policy, UAE policy toward Iran has shifted repeatedly since the conflict began. The UAE moved from pre-war wariness of confrontation to a more hawkish posture after hostilities began, then toward cautious engagement as the conflict continued.³⁰ In August 2026, however, the UAE again adopted a tougher position toward Iran, as the UAE Foreign Ministry announced the suspension of all trade activity, commercial exchanges, and financial transactions with Iran until further notice.³¹ The shift is particularly significant given the UAE's longstanding role as a major trading partner of Iran; as of 2024, the UAE accounted for approximately one-third of Iranian imports. Reportedly, the policy change came at the behest of the United States, which had sought Emirati cooperation in tightening sanctions and trade restrictions against Iran.³² Dubai's special economic zones have long been used by Iranian-linked entities to evade U.S. and international sanctions; dozens of Emirati entities have been designated for U.S. sanctions for their role in various Iran-related transactions, particularly related to Iran's oil exports.³³ Though Emirati sanctions enforcement is notoriously uneven, for both capacity and policy reasons, the UAE is expected to "move step by step, beginning with new restrictions on cargo and potentially expanding to a broader crackdown on Iranian-linked entities if the Revolutionary Guard continues its strikes."³⁴ According to one analysis, "The majority of Iran's transshipment, smuggling, and shadow banking activity takes place in Dubai, so Washington must do what it can to help the UAE's national leaders in Abu Dhabi convince and cajole Dubai's leaders to play ball."³⁵

However, as of early September 2026, the UAE rhetoric vis-à-vis Iran has again shifted or even softened, as officials have acknowledged the reality of Iran's proximity and the need "to find some new channels of understanding."³⁶ At the recent BRICS Summit in New Delhi, India, Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed Al Nahyan (the UAE President's son and designated successor) met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian for bilateral talks. At the United Nations (UN) General Assembly in New York, UAE diplomatic advisor Anwar Gargash said "Iran remains our neighbour, and at some point we will have to find a way to restore what can be restored.... Geography leaves us no alternative to engagement."³⁷

²⁹ Omar Abdel-Baqi and Summer Said, "Economies Across Mideast Face Poor Outlook as War Drags On," *Wall Street Journal*, September 4, 2026.

³⁰ Andrew England and Nicolas Parasie, "The UAE's Bold Gambit on Iran," *Financial Times*, July 28, 2026; and Susannah George, "Frustration with Trump grows among U.S.'s Persian Gulf allies, officials say," *Washington Post*, August 15, 2026.

³¹ "UAE suspends all trade and financial transactions with Iran until further notice," *Gulf News*, August 19, 2026.

³² Summer Said, Georgi Kantchev, and Robbie Gramer, "Trump's Plan to Squeeze Iran's Economy Will Live or Die in Dubai," *Wall Street Journal*, August 19, 2026.

³³ U.S. Department of the Treasury, "Financial Trend Analysis: Iranian Shadow Banking: Trends in Bank Secrecy Act Data," October 2025.

³⁴ Said et al., "Trump's Plan to Squeeze Iran's Economy Will Live or Die in Dubai."

³⁵ Matthew Levitt and Maya Chaovat, "Shutting Iran's Emirati Back Door to Banks and Supply Chains," Policywatch #4252, The Washington Institute for Near East Policy, August 25, 2026.

³⁶ "UAE presidential adviser Gargash says trust with Iran will take years to rebuild," *Euronews*, September 17, 2026.

³⁷ Andrew England, "Gulf states urge reset with Iran as conflict drags on," *Financial Times*, September 21, 2026.

While the UAE may be acknowledging its vulnerabilities vis-à-vis Iran, it has aligned itself with the United States' Operation Economic Outcast to pressure Iran financially.³⁸ One report indicated that while the UAE (and Saudi Arabia) do not seek a return to full scale hostilities, both Gulf countries have been advocating for continued U.S. economic pressure on Iran.³⁹

On August 28, the U.S. Department of the Treasury's Financial Crimes Enforcement Network (FinCEN) proposed a rule that would revoke the UAE branch of Egypt's Banque Misr from access to U.S. financial institutions.⁴⁰ Perhaps in response to the sanctions, the National Bank of Egypt may acquire Banque Misr's UAE branch.⁴¹ The UAE's central bank has imposed sanctions on the Emirati branches of Iran's Bank Melli. As of late September 2026, Iranian commercial flights to the UAE had been cancelled.

The UAE and Israel

In 2020, the UAE and Israel normalized relations in the first of the Abraham Accords. In support of this normalization, the first Trump Administration pledged to sell to the UAE the advanced F-35 Joint Strike Fighter aircraft and armed drones.⁴² In the last hours of the first Trump Administration, the UAE signed Letters of Acceptance to purchase up to 50 F-35s and 18 MQ-9 Reaper drones from the United States (reportedly as an incentive for signing the Abraham Accords).⁴³ The Biden Administration temporarily paused the sale for review upon taking office in 2021, partially due to concerns over UAE-People's Republic of China ties.⁴⁴ The UAE Air Force subsequently sent a letter to the U.S. Department of Defense in 2021 withdrawing its Letters of Acceptance for the F-35 and MQ-9. Since 2021, the U.S. and UAE governments have engaged in periodic negotiations over the sales, though a final agreement has remained elusive. The Trump Administration's September 2026 proposal to sell 48 F-35s and related systems and training to Saudi Arabia may revive Emirati interest in the platform.

For the first three years (2020-2023) of normalization, Emirati-Israeli relations flourished, as trade, tourism, military, and diplomatic ties expanded significantly. In May 2022, Israel and the UAE signed a free trade agreement. In 2023, bilateral trade reached \$2.95 billion, up from just a few hundred million before the Accords.⁴⁵ In February 2023, the UAE inaugurated a multi-faith complex known as the "Abrahamic Family House," which contains a Jewish synagogue. The UAE also has purchased arms from Israel, including various air and missile defense systems.⁴⁶

³⁸ U.S. Department of the Treasury, "Treasury Launches Unprecedented Campaign Against Iranian Regime on Economic D-Day, August 24, 2026.

³⁹ Summer Said and Benoit Faucon, "Gulf Oil Producers Push To Keep Pressure on Tehran," *Wall Street Journal*, September 25, 2026.

⁴⁰ U.S. Department of the Treasury, "FinCEN Proposes Rule that Would Revoke Banque Misr UAE's Correspondent Banking Access to U.S. Financial Institutions," August 28, 2026.

⁴¹ "Egypt's NBE steps in to buy Banque Misr's UAE operations after sanctions threat," Reuters, September 22, 2026.

⁴² See CRS Report R46580, *Israel's Qualitative Military Edge and Possible U.S. Arms Sales to the United Arab Emirates*, coordinated by Jeremy M. Sharp and Jim Zanotti.

⁴³ Mike Stone, "UAE Signs Deal with U.S. to Buy 50 F-35 Jets and up to 18 Drones: Sources," Reuters, January 20, 2021.

⁴⁴ Mohammed Soliman, "The Gulf Has a 5G Conundrum and Open RAN Is the Key to Its Tech Sovereignty," Middle East Institute, January 12, 2022.

⁴⁵ "Gaza War Cools Israel's Once Red-Hot Business Ties with UAE," Reuters, May 8, 2024.

⁴⁶ Elizabeth Dent, "Israel-UAE Defense Cooperation Grows Under the Abraham Accords," The Washington Institute for Near East Policy, August 5, 2025.

The next three years (2023-2026) of Emirati-Israeli normalization, which have been defined by the post-October 7, 2023 conflicts in Gaza, Lebanon, and Iran, have witnessed unprecedented levels of military cooperation, but also strained diplomatic ties over Israeli military action across the Middle East. In Gaza, the UAE has been one of the largest country donors of humanitarian aid, and the coordination of aid delivery necessitates close cooperation between the Israeli and Emirati governments and militaries. However, in 2025, when some ultranationalist members of Israel's governing coalition suggested that Israel annex part of the West Bank, the UAE said that such a step would trigger downgraded ties with Israel.⁴⁷ Israel's September 2025 strike against Hamas negotiators in Qatar elicited a particularly sharp response from Emirati officials.⁴⁸

Despite tensions, Emirati-Israeli trade, investment, and defense ties are ongoing. In January 2025, the UAE's main defense company, EDGE, bought a minority stake in Israel's Thirdeye Systems, a developer of drone-detection systems. Reportedly, the UAE may also have entered into a significant defense export agreement with the Israeli defense firm Elbit Systems, worth \$2.3 billion over eight years; this deal could be for Israel's Hermes 900 unmanned aerial vehicles.⁴⁹

In 2026, U.S.-Israel strikes on Iran and resulting Iranian strikes on the UAE illustrate the perils and promise of closer Emirati-Israeli ties. On the one hand, the UAE accepted an Israeli military presence on its soil to operate Iron Dome batteries.⁵⁰ UAE officials also attended a recent roundtable with representatives from various Abraham Accords signatories, including Israel.⁵¹ On the other hand, there appears to have been a general erosion of trust between Emirati and Israeli leaders, perhaps exacerbated by the apparent leak of a secret visit by Prime Minister Netanyahu to the UAE to the press in May 2026.⁵²

In September 2026, Israeli media reported that UAE President Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan (MBZ) warned Netanyahu a week prior to the October 7, 2023 terrorist attacks that Hamas was planning a major operation against Israel.⁵³ The UAE Foreign Ministry declined to comment on the specific media reporting. Netanyahu then made another visit to the UAE in late September 2026 reportedly to ask MBZ to deny reports of any UAE 2023 Hamas warning.⁵⁴ Also, in September,

On balance, the fact that the UAE cannot fully defend itself against Iranian aggression without external assistance may motivate continued Emirati-Israeli defense cooperation, even if Emirati policy quietly returns to a policy of general rapprochement with Iran.⁵⁵

⁴⁷ "Exclusive: UAE could downgrade diplomatic ties if Israel annexes West Bank, sources say," Reuters, September 18, 2025.

⁴⁸ "UAE summons deputy Israeli ambassador over attack on Hamas in Qatar," Reuters, September 12, 2025.

⁴⁹ Dean Shmuel Elmas, "United Arab Emirates named as Elbit's mystery \$2.3 billion customer – report," *Jerusalem Post*, December 18, 2025.

⁵⁰ "Minister confirms Israel deployed Iron Dome battery to UAE during war," *Times of Israel*, July 5, 2026.

⁵¹ Amichai Stein, "Abraham Accords partners meet, 1st time since '23," *Jerusalem Post*, September 27, 2026.

⁵² Nava Freiberg, "Iran war fallout puts UAE on tightrope between Jerusalem and Tehran," *Times of Israel*, June 28, 2026.

⁵³ "Revealed: Netanyahu Received an Explicit Warning Days Before Oct. 7. He Didn't Brief Israel's Security Chiefs," *Ha'aretz*, September 8, 2026.

⁵⁴ "Netanyahu meets Emirati leader in a secret weekend trip to Abu Dhabi," Associated Press, September 28, 2026.

⁵⁵ Giorgio Cafiero, "After the Iran War, is the UAE the odd man out?" *Responsible Statecraft*, June 18, 2026.

UAE Involvement in the Middle East and North Africa and its Rivalry with Saudi Arabia

For over a decade, the UAE has exerted its influence and pursued national interests in war-torn, politically unstable countries, such as Yemen, Libya, Ethiopia, Somalia, and Sudan (see **below**). The reasons for Emirati foreign intervention are complex. Beyond the basic goal of growing state power, MBZ may seek to counter political Islamist movements (e.g., the Muslim Brotherhood which he may view as radical and destabilizing) in parts of the Middle East and Africa.⁵⁶ Sometimes, this anti-Islamist agenda also coincides with a deliberate Emirati strategy to acquire strategic land and mineral resources.⁵⁷ The UAE also seeks foreign markets for its government-backed companies, particularly in the logistics sector (e.g., Dubai-based port operator DP World).⁵⁸ Overall, the UAE most likely sees itself as an opportunistic and key player in a global competition for political, economic, and military influence in parts of the world where more powerful nations are less engaged.⁵⁹

UAE involvement in some of these arenas has at times put it into direct conflict with Saudi Arabia, as the two countries differ in their positions on political Islam and Israel and race to be best positioned for a global energy future that is possibly less reliant on hydrocarbon extraction and production.⁶⁰ In recent years, the UAE and Saudi Arabia have backed different or competing factions in Yemen and Sudan (see **below**). In Yemen, the UAE and Saudi Arabia have backed different elements of forces opposed to the Iran-backed Houthis. The UAE has backed the southern separatist Southern Transition Council (STC) while Saudi Arabia has backed Al Islah party, a coalition of tribal and Islamist leaders.

The UAE and Sudan

As civil war in Sudan continues between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the insurgent paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF), press reports and UN monitors have implicated the UAE in backing the RSF; the UAE continues to reject the allegations.⁶¹

U.S. officials have avoided publicly accusing the UAE of arming the RSF—which per the State Department has committed genocide in Sudan’s Darfur region—but stated that such support—from any source should stop.⁶² According to press reports and some Members of Congress, Biden

⁵⁶ Robert Worth, “Mohammed bin Zayed’s Dark Vision of the Middle East’s Future,” *New York Times*, January 9, 2020 and “UAE’s newly elected ruler sees Iran, Islamists as threat to Gulf safe haven,” Reuters, May 14, 2022.

⁵⁷ Declan Walsh and Tariq Panja, “The Sheikh Who Conquered Soccer and Coddles Warlords,” *New York Times*, June 29, 2025.

⁵⁸ “Syria signs \$800m Tartous port deal with UAE firm DP World,” *Al Jazeera*, July 13, 2025.

⁵⁹ “The UAE in Africa: Power, Influence and Conflict,” *Bloomberg*, July 8, 2025.

⁶⁰ Abeer Abu Omar, “Riyadh Vs. Dubai,” *Bloomberg*, April 10, 2023.

⁶¹ United Nations, Final Report of the Panel of Experts on Sudan, UN doc. S/2024/65; UN Human Rights Council, *Fueling Sudan’s conflict: weapons, fighters and external support networks – Report of the independent international fact-finding mission for the Sudan*, UN doc. A/HRC/63/23, September 1, 2026; *The Guardian*, “Leaked UN experts report raises fresh concerns over UAE’s role in Sudan war,” April 14, 2025; and “UAE denies involvement in Sudan war, calls for end to foreign military support,” *Gulf News*, September 4, 2026.

⁶² See, e.g., State Department, Secretary of State Marco Rubio Remarks to the Press, November 12, 2025; State Department, “Genocide Determination in Sudan and Imposing Accountability Measures,” January 7, 2025; and U.S. Mission to the United Nations (USUN), Remarks at UN Security Council Briefing on July 10, 2025 and October 30, 2025.

Administration officials in a briefing confirmed the UAE's role in weapons transfers.⁶³ Under the Biden Administration, the Department of the Treasury has designated multiple UAE-based companies linked to the RSF for sanctions, including one that has provided Colombian mercenaries to the RSF.⁶⁴

UAE officials have cited "the re-emergence of Muslim Brotherhood influence" in Sudan as a major concern,⁶⁵ and Emirati media has highlighted the role of other foreign actors in providing drones to the SAF for use in civilian areas and the SAF's alleged use of chemical weapons.⁶⁶

UAE interest in Sudan may be part of a broader regional UAE strategy in the Red Sea/Horn of Africa to invest financially and engage various governments and non-state actors militarily.⁶⁷ Among East African countries, the largest Emirati engagements have been in Sudan, where the UAE has been the single largest investor among regional actors, with a reported \$22 billion in non-security initiatives.⁶⁸

While the UAE has drawn international criticism for its clandestine support of the RSF, the United States has continued to include the UAE government in the "Quad," a U.S.-led diplomatic initiative to end the conflict, that also includes Saudi Arabia and Egypt, which are seen as aligned with the SAF. The UAE has expressed its commitment to the Quad and has emphasized that "an immediate ceasefire would strengthen ongoing efforts to support a sustainable, civilian political solution that places the interests of the Sudanese people above all else."⁶⁹

U.S.-Emirati Relations

Over the past two decades, the UAE has become one of the United States' closest partners in the Middle East region.⁷⁰ Those ties have been strengthened during the Trump Administration. Gulf countries like the UAE have increasingly emerged as arenas for competition with China, particularly in the race for AI dominance. In January 2026, the UAE joined Pax Silica, the U.S. State Department's multilateral AI and supply chain security initiative. In June 2026, Secretary of State Marco Rubio traveled to the UAE where he "reaffirmed the U.S. commitment to the security of the Emirates."⁷¹

⁶³ See, e.g., Declan Walsh and Christoph Koettl, "How a U.S. Ally Uses Aid as a Cover in War," *New York Times*, September 21, 2024; Senator Chris Van Hollen, "Van Hollen, Jacobs confirm UAE providing weapons to RSF in Sudan, in contradiction to its assurances to US," January 24, 2025.

⁶⁴ Department of the Treasury, "Treasury Sanctions Transnational Network Recruiting Colombians to Fight in Sudan's Civil War," December 9, 2025 and "Treasury Sanctions Sudanese Paramilitary Leader, Weapons Supplier, and Related Companies," January 7, 2025.

⁶⁵ *Emirates News Agency*, "Gargash: Sudan's tragic civil war must come to an immediate end," November 22, 2025; *The Guardian*, "As criticism grow, is UAE ready to walk away from Sudan's RSF militia?" November 4, 2025.

⁶⁶ "UN report finds Sudanese Armed Forces used foreign-supplied drones in attacks on civilian areas," *The National*, September 3, 2026 and "Former investigators have 'every reason to believe' chemical weapons were used in Sudan," *The National*, September 15, 2026.

⁶⁷ Patricia Cohen, "U.A.E. Is Pouring Money Into Africa, Seeking Resources and Power," *New York Times*, May 27, 2025.

⁶⁸ Africa Center for Strategic Studies, "Mapping Gulf State Actors' Expanding Engagements in East Africa," July 8, 2025.

⁶⁹ United Arab Emirates Foreign Ministry, "UAE Welcomes Comprehensive Peace Plan for Sudan Announced by U.S. Senior Advisor Boulos," February 8, 2026.

⁷⁰ Abigail Hauslohner, "How the UAE won over Washington," *Financial Times*, August 10, 2026.

⁷¹ U.S. Department of State, "Secretary Rubio's Meeting with UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan," June 24, 2026.

Though U.S.-Emirati ties remain strong, the UAE's ongoing rivalry with Saudi Arabia in both the commercial and diplomatic spheres have complicated U.S. efforts to forge a common regional response to various challenges in war-torn countries, such as Yemen and Sudan.⁷² As the conflict in the Gulf continues, U.S. policymakers may seek greater Emirati-Saudi cooperation against common threats.⁷³ In Yemen, where the UAE and Saudi Arabia backed different factions aligned against the Iran-backed Houthis and where Saudi Arabia is now embroiled in renewed conflict, U.S. officials have been privately urging Emirati-Saudi reconciliation.⁷⁴ In late September 2026, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman held talks with UAE Vice President Sheikh Mansour bin Zayed al Nahyan.

From 1950 to 2024, the United States implemented more than \$33.5 billion in Foreign Military Sales for the UAE, making it the 14th largest U.S. defense customer by value worldwide.⁷⁵ From 2016 to 2025, the United States also authorized the export of over \$11.3 billion in defense articles to the UAE via the Direct Commercial Sales (DCS) process, primarily launch vehicles, aircraft, munitions, and military electronics.⁷⁶ Since the conflict with Iran began in February 2026, the Administration has notified Congress of an estimated \$8.6 billion in possible U.S. Foreign Military Sales to the UAE (see **Table 1**). On March 26, 2026, Senator Chris Van Hollen proposed a Joint Resolution of Disapproval (S.J.Res. 158) to the proposed sale of F-16 munitions notified to Congress on March 19. For several years, Senator Van Hollen and others have proposed legislation (S. 935, H.R. 2509) to prohibit U.S. arms sales to the UAE until the President certifies that the UAE is not providing materiel support to the Rapid Support Forces in Sudan.

Table 1. Recent U.S. Foreign Military Sales to the UAE

Date	Equipment	Estimated Value	Prime Contractor
March 19, 2026	Long-Range Discrimination Radar with Terminal High Altitude Area Defense Integration	\$4.5 billion	Lockheed Martin Corporation
March 19, 2026	Advanced Medium-Range Air-to-Air Missiles (AMRAAMs)	\$1.22 billion	RTX Corporation
March 19, 2026	Fixed Site- Low, Slow, Small Unmanned Aircraft Integrated Defeat System (FS-LIDS)	\$2.10 billion	RTX Corporation, Northrop Grumman, and SRC Corporation
March 19, 2026	F-16 munitions and upgrades	\$644 million	Lockheed Martin Corporation
May 1, 2026	Advanced Precision Kill Weapon System (APKWS)	\$147.6 million	BAE Systems, Inc.

Source: U.S. Department of State, Foreign Military Sales: Congressional Notification, Bureau of Political-Military Affairs.

⁷² Ismaeel Naar, "What to Know About the Growing Saudi Arabia-U.A.E. Rift," *New York Times*, May 5, 2026.

⁷³ James Jeffrey, "Trump's GCC Meeting: A Path Out of the Conflict," PolicyWatch #4266, The Washington Institute for Near East Policy, September 21, 2026.

⁷⁴ "Saudi Arabia urged to reconcile with UAE to drive back Houthi separatists in Yemen," *The Guardian* (UK), September 29, 2026.

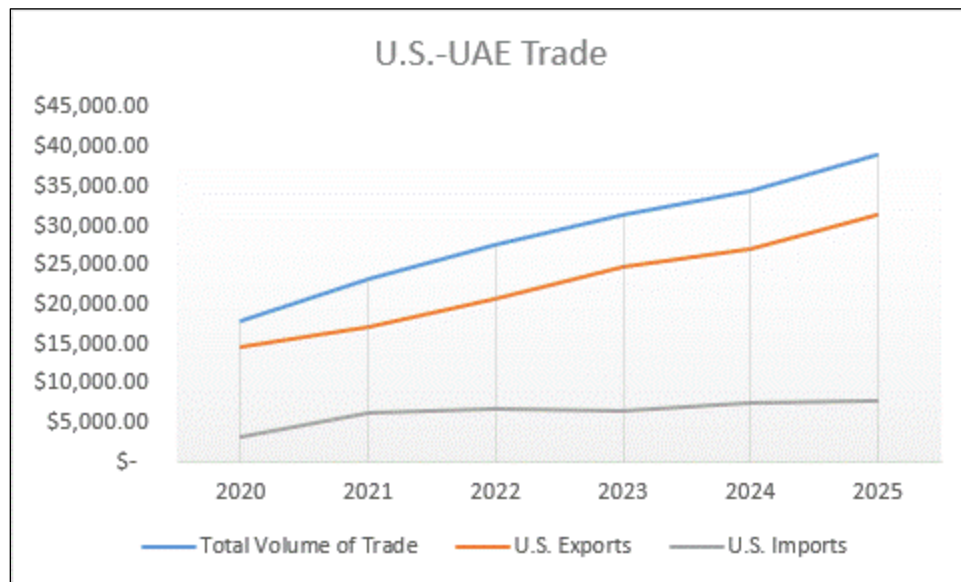
⁷⁵ U.S. Defense Security Cooperation Agency (DSCA), *Historical Sales Book Fiscal Years 1950 to 2024*, FY2024 Edition.

⁷⁶ U.S. Department of State, "U.S. Security Cooperation with the United Arab Emirates," fact sheet, January 20, 2025.

The United States and the UAE have established a “Defense Cooperation Framework” to develop joint approaches to regional conflicts and to promote U.S.-UAE interoperability. On May 15, 2017, the United States and the UAE confirmed that they had concluded negotiations on a new Defense Cooperation Agreement (DCA) with a 15-year duration, which came into force as of May 30, 2019.⁷⁷ The DCA is not a mutual defense treaty.

Figure 2. U.S.-UAE Bilateral Trade: 2020-2025

Nominal U.S. dollars in millions



Source: U.S. Census Bureau, <https://www.census.gov/foreign-trade/balance/c5200.html#2025>.

In 2025, the UAE was the largest U.S. trading partner by value (\$39 billion) in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region.⁷⁸ The UAE has remained the top U.S. export destination for the entire MENA region for the 17th year in a row, and the United States has a trade surplus of \$23 billion with the UAE (see **Figure 2**). According to the U.S. Department of Commerce, the UAE is a “global hub for over 1,500 American companies.”⁷⁹ The current baseline U.S. tariff rate on most goods imported from the UAE is 10%; tariffs on aluminum imported from the UAE are 50%.

Historical Background

From the mid-18th to the mid-19th century, the emirates were under the sway of the United Kingdom and were known as the “Trucial States,” a term derived from a series of maritime truces among the several emirates negotiated under British auspices. For over a century and until independence in 1971, the Trucial States functioned as informal British protectorates, with Britain conducting foreign and defense relations on their behalf.⁸⁰

⁷⁷ DOD, “SecDef Meets with UAE’s Crown Prince,” May 15, 2017, and “UAE-US Defence Agreement Kicks in as John Bolton Visits Abu Dhabi,” *The National* (UAE), May 30, 2019.

⁷⁸ International Trade Administration, “TradeStats Express—U.S. Trade by Partners,” 2025.

⁷⁹ U.S. Department of Commerce, International Trade Administration, “Country Commercial Guide, United Arab Emirates.”

⁸⁰ “Trucial States in 1914,” The National Archives, Government of the United Kingdom.

During most of this period, the Trucial States' mostly semi-nomadic population focused on pearl diving, merchandise trade, and date cultivation. Oil exploration in the Trucial States began in the 1930s; the discovery and eventual export of oil in Abu Dhabi in the late 1950s and early 1960s helped transform the emirates politically and economically from a relatively impoverished area dependent on British protection into an independent nation with the Arab world's second largest GDP.

When the British government announced its intent to withdraw from bases "East of Suez" in 1968, the Trucial States and other Gulf sheikhdoms (Bahrain and Qatar) began deliberations over possible federation. Internally and prior to independence, the various ruling families of the Trucial States had cooperated with the British in delineating borders among themselves and forming a Trucial Council to discuss political matters. Externally, Britain, along with the United States, worked to ensure that larger Gulf powers, such as Saudi Arabia and Iran, would not impede federation, despite their respective claims on territories within the emirates.⁸¹ After three years of negotiations, Qatar and Bahrain decided to become independent nations. The emirates acquired full independence from Britain on December 1, 1971. Six of them—Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Fujairah, Ajman, and Umm al Qaywayn—immediately banded together to form the UAE. A seventh, Ra's al Khaymah, joined the federation early in 1972.

In its half-century of independence, the UAE has had three presidents; their domestic and foreign policies have evolved from an early focus on state building, development, and close ties to the West to becoming a more emboldened, global actor that has retained close Western ties while expanding relationships further East. Under the late Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan al Nahyan (president from 1971-2004), Abu Dhabi used its oil wealth to invest heavily in infrastructure development, as well as federal institutions that could bond a society traditionally divided along various tribal, familial, and geographic lines. Nevertheless, strengthening Emirati national identity took time; the federal army was only truly united in 1997 when Dubai disbanded its armed forces.

During the reign of Sheikh Khalifa bin Zayed al Nahyan (president from 2004 to 2022), the UAE focused on diversifying its economy. In Dubai, which has far less oil than Abu Dhabi, Sheikh Mohammad bin Rashid al Maktoum transformed the city-state into a global commercial center centered on finance, real estate, shipping, and tourism.⁸² While Abu Dhabi and Dubai have long competed commercially and culturally, Abu Dhabi's oil wealth has undergirded the UAE's growth; during the 2008-2009 financial crisis, Dubai's real estate market crashed, and Abu Dhabi lent it \$20 billion in bailout funds.

Domestic Politics and Society

The UAE's political system is notably stable. The dynastic rulers of each of the seven emirates exercise power within their respective principalities over "all authorities that are not assigned by the Constitution to the Federation."⁸³ Per the constitution, the Federal Supreme Council, which comprises the hereditary leaders of all the emirates, has the power to elect a new president upon

⁸¹ In 1971, the Shah-led government of Iran seized the Greater and Lesser Tunb islands from the emirate of Ra's al Khaymah and compelled the emirate of Sharjah to share with Iran control of Abu Musa island. In April 1992, the Islamic Republic of Iran took complete control of Abu Musa and placed some military equipment there. When the UAE achieved its independence in 1971, Saudi Arabia continued its unresolved border dispute with Abu Dhabi over the Al Buraymi Oasis, which was ultimately resolved by the 1974 Treaty of Jeddah.

⁸² The emir of Dubai has traditionally served as vice president and prime minister.

⁸³ United Arab Emirates, "The Cabinet (Federal System)," available at <https://uaecabinet.ae/en/federal-system>.

death or resignation of the sitting ruler.⁸⁴ The Council is the highest federal executive and legislative authority in the UAE. Since the founding of the state, the ruler of Abu Dhabi has served as the federation's president, and the presidential transition in 2022 (like the previous one in 2004) followed constitutional procedures.⁸⁵ The UAE president has the legal authority to sign laws and issue decrees (in areas assigned to the federation under the constitution), appoint/dismiss cabinet ministers, and conduct the nation's foreign affairs.

The UAE does not have an independent legislative body, though it has provided for some formal popular representation of citizens through a 40-seat advisory Federal National Council (FNC)—a body that can debate laws and review government policies, but not legislate independently. The FNC can summon ministers for questioning, but it is not empowered to remove them. Half of the FNC's seats are appointed; the other half are directly elected by limited suffrage among selected UAE citizens.⁸⁶ According to a 2018 presidential decree, Emirati women must hold 50% of the council's seats.

The UAE has a dual judicial system with a mix of federal courts and state courts within some individual emirates. Sharia (Islamic law) is the principal source of legislation, though courts may apply civil or sharia law depending on circumstances. According to the constitution, federal law supersedes local law, though each emirate can enact laws not expressly reserved for the federal government, or in areas in which the federal government has not legislated. A Federal Supreme Court, appointed by the UAE leadership, adjudicates disputes between emirates or between an emirate and the UAE federal government. Additionally, the Federal Supreme Court adjudicates over state security cases, wherein its verdicts are final and cannot be appealed. Abu Dhabi and Dubai also have special economic zones with respective separate court systems to settle commercial and civil disputes. Each individual emirate maintains its own police forces, which enforce both local and federal law and are officially subsumed within the Federal Ministry of the Interior.

The Emirati federal government and each individual emirate maintain generous social welfare systems for Emirati citizens. In the UAE, Emirati citizens pay no personal income tax. Education is compulsory and free. Emirati citizens are entitled to universal health care. The state also maintains a vast subsidy system, particularly for low-income citizens. The UAE's Social Welfare Program provides its citizens with subsidies for housing, unemployment support, food, fuel, water, and electricity. Many citizens who have worked in both the public and private sectors are entitled to pensions upon reaching retirement eligibility.

The UAE's population consists mostly of expatriates, who make up a higher share of the UAE's population than any other GCC state (see **Figure 2**). The federal government has sought to attract and retain skilled foreign labor to help make the economy globally competitive, and has reformed and liberalized some laws in apparent efforts to do so. The UAE faces competition from Saudi Arabia and other Gulf neighbors that similarly seek to be a hub for global commerce. In 2021, the federal government decriminalized premarital sex and cohabitation; ("homosexual activities are illegal," per the State Department). The Abu Dhabi Dubai governments also removed the requirement for a license to purchase or consume alcohol. A federal law on the personal status of non-Muslims allows for civil law to govern marriage, divorce, inheritance, and child custody for

⁸⁴ An English language translation of the UAE's 1996 constitution is available at <https://www.refworld.org/pdfid/48eca8132.pdf>.

⁸⁵ George Sadek, "United Arab Emirates: Supreme Council Elects New President of the Union," *Global Legal Monitor*, Law Library of Congress, June 9, 2022.

⁸⁶ For information on the regulations pertaining to FNC elections, see <https://www.mfnca.gov.ae/en/home>.

non-Muslims.⁸⁷ In 2021, the UAE amended its citizenship law, allowing a pathway to citizenship for certain categories of foreigners from select career fields.⁸⁸ In the emirate of Ras al Khaimah, the Wynn Casino company is building a resort and gaming complex, in what would become the first casino to operate in any of the GCC states; to date, the UAE has yet to legalize gambling, which is prohibited in Islam.⁸⁹ The UAE also runs a Golden Residency program, which offers foreigners long-term residency (five to ten years with possible renewal) based on income and investment qualifications.

The UAE, like other GCC countries, has attempted to encourage more of its own citizens to be active participants in the private sector labor force. According to the country's "Emiratisation" laws, private sector companies with over 50 employees must have at least 3% of their payroll consist of Emirati citizens; noncompliance results in steep fines, though the government has offered to subsidize a portion of its citizens' salaries from private employers.⁹⁰ Despite these efforts, studies indicate that Emirati students lag internationally on key educational performance benchmarks; some contend that "the promise of a public-sector job, regardless of ability, offered little motivation to work hard in school."⁹¹ In 2024, the ruler of Dubai claimed that, for the first time, the number of Emirati citizens working in the private sector had exceeded 100,000, due, in part, to government programs designed to incentivize local hiring.⁹²

Figure 3. Migrant Population by Percentage in the GCC



Sources: *The Economist* and United Nations.

Notes: m = millions. Each bubble depicts the number of migrants in each country, while each bar shows what percentage of the country's total population that number represents.

Human Rights, Women's Rights, Foreign Labor, and Trafficking in Persons

According to the U.S. Department of State, significant human rights issues in the UAE include, among other things, credible reports of: "disappearances; arbitrary arrest or detention; transnational repression against individuals in another country; serious restrictions on freedom of expression and media freedom, including censorship; and prohibiting independent trade unions or

⁸⁷ "UAE Issues Personal Status Federal Decree- Law for Non-Muslims in the Country," Emirates News Agency (WAM) (UAE), December 9, 2022.

⁸⁸ "UAE Adopts Amendments to Grant Citizenship to Investors and Other Professionals," Reuters, January 30, 2021.

⁸⁹ Zainab Fattah, "The First Casino Near Dubai Sparks a Region's Newest Gold Rush," *Bloomberg*, June 13, 2024.

⁹⁰ Rory Reynolds, "Emiratisation Explained: What Are the New Rules and Fines?" *The National* (UAE), July 12, 2023.

⁹¹ "Reinventing the Gulf: A New Dawn, a New Day," *The Economist*, February 11, 2023.

⁹² "Number of Emiratis Working in Private Sector Tops 100,000 for First Time," *The National* (UAE), May 26, 2024.

significant or systematic restrictions on workers' freedom of association."⁹³ The nongovernmental organization Freedom House classifies the UAE as "not free."⁹⁴

According to the World Economic Forum's 2026 Global Gender Gap report, the UAE ranks 91st overall in the report's global gender gap index and second overall in the Middle East and North Africa, behind Israel.⁹⁵ This score may reflect the high educational attainment of Emirati women and government attempts to encourage their political participation. The UAE has reformed legal provisions to prohibit discrimination on the basis of sex and gender, while enacting a domestic violence law permitting women to obtain restraining orders against abusers. The UAE Air Force has several female fighter pilots, and, in 2021, Nora al Matrooshi was named the UAE's first female astronaut.⁹⁶

Overall, UAE law governing certain personal matters differs for Muslim Emirati citizens and non-Muslim expatriates. For the former, the Personal Status Law, which is based on sharia law, governs policies on marriage, divorce, and child custody.

The UAE is a "destination country" for women trafficked from Asia, Africa, and the countries of the former Soviet Union and forced into prostitution. The Department of State's Trafficking in Persons report for 2025, for the 14th year in a row, rated the UAE as "Tier 2," based on the assessment that the UAE "does not fully meet the minimum standards for the elimination of trafficking but is making significant efforts to do so."⁹⁷ In a 2023 investigative exposé published by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists and Reuters, journalists concluded that "the UAE is a major destination for sex trafficking, where African women are forced into prostitution by illicit networks operating within the country.... Emirati authorities do little to protect these women, according to anti-trafficking activists, Nigerian authorities and interviews with trafficked women."⁹⁸ Dubai has a police unit tasked solely with assisting victims of trafficking.⁹⁹

A significant percentage of the UAE's expatriate workforce comprises low-paid, unskilled and semi-skilled laborers and domestic workers, predominantly from South Asia. UAE law prohibits all forms of compulsory labor, but enforcement is inconsistent. Foreign laborers have sometimes conducted strikes to protest poor working conditions, nonpayment of wages, and cramped housing conditions. Workers still reportedly sometimes have their passports withheld, are denied wages or paid late, and are deported for lodging complaints. The federal government has put in place an electronic salary payment system that applies to companies with more than 100 workers, facilitating timely payment of agreed wages. In 2022, the UAE government issued a federal decree aimed at creating better work conditions for domestic workers.¹⁰⁰

⁹³ U.S. Department of State, *Country Reports on Human Rights Practices 2024: United Arab Emirates*.

⁹⁴ See <https://freedomhouse.org/country/united-arab-emirates>.

⁹⁵ World Economic Forum, "Global Gender Gap Report 2026," September 16, 2026.

⁹⁶ "The United Arab Emirates Has Announced Its First Female Astronaut," CNN, April 10, 2021.

⁹⁷ U.S. Department of State, "2025 Trafficking in Persons Report: United Arab Emirates."

⁹⁸ Maggie Michael, "How Torture, Deception and Inaction Underpin UAE's Thriving Sex Trafficking Industry," Reuters, June 12, 2023.

⁹⁹ "Minister of Justice Sets Out UAE's Fight Against 'Heinous' Human Trafficking," *The National* (UAE), July 30, 2023.

¹⁰⁰ "United Arab Emirates: New Law Regulating Work of Foreign Domestic Workers Adopted," *Global Legal Monitor*, The Law Library, Library of Congress, January 5, 2023.

Analysis: UAE Foreign Relations and U.S. Ties

Amid the events of 2026 and their impact on the region, the UAE is adjusting to a new security and economic environment, while other Gulf countries, such as Saudi Arabia, continue to confront Iranian-backed groups such as the Houthis. Against this backdrop, the UAE's relationship with the United States faces uncertainty. On the one hand, no other single external power can provide military assistance to the UAE to the same extent as the United States. U.S. arms sales to the Emirates have increased notably over the past nine months, and cooperation in other areas, such as artificial intelligence, remains robust. On the other hand, if the conflicts in the Gulf result in a more assertive Iran, with much of its proxy network intact, and a perception of diminished U.S. deterrence, the UAE may face difficult choices over whether and how to reduce its dependence on the United States without alienating its most important security partner by embracing U.S. competitors. Alternatively, increased U.S.-UAE economic pressure on Iran could contribute to diminished Iranian influence and an outcome that reinforces bilateral cooperation. Although the situation remains fluid, regardless of the Iran conflict's outcome, the UAE appears unlikely to retreat from its ambitions to become a global commercial center, even if the current conflict has increased the cost of pursuing those ambitions.

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